

The Purrfect Friend

Arushi was sad. They had just shifted to this big new town and she was **sorely** missing everything at her **dear** old town where she had lived till now.

"Why don't you go out?" her mother asked.

"Make new friends, I'm sure you'll find some good kids out there!"

Arushi too knew that, but she felt too **shy** to **venture out** and ask **strange** children to be her friends. How can you just **walk up** to a stranger and ask something like that? She never had had to do that in Ajmer — all her friends and she had simply grown up together!

She **dragged on** her woollen jacket and **stepped out**.

"Might just as well see what the neighborhood is like," she said to herself.

In the colony park nearby, she saw some girls playing **hopscotch** and **longed** to join them. They seemed to be having great fun. But all of them looked so **smartly turned out**, Arushi felt **scruffy** in comparison.

Hesitantly, she walked up to them and stood watching. Not one of them even turned to look at her! They simply **went on** playing and ignoring her. How unfriendly! Getting slightly red in the face, Arushi **walked away**. She **fancied** she heard someone say "Townie, townie" as the others **burst into giggles**.



Who wanted to be friends with such **snooties**? She was **about to** walk out of the park **in a huff**, when she heard a **pitiful mew** from the tree under which she was standing. She looked up and saw the cutest white and brown **kitten perched on** a branch, mewing for all it was worth. At a distance, there was a big stray dog who had obviously chased **the little thing** up there.

Arushi looked around. She had to **rescue** the poor kitten, but just as she was **wondering** if she should climb up the tree, she saw a **pleasantly plump** lady rush into the park and talk worriedly to one of the girls playing hopscotch. To Arushi's surprise, the girl **burst into tears**!

"But Mom!" she cried loud enough for Arushi to hear,

"Kitty was so little! What'll happen to her?"

It wasn't difficult for Arushi to **put two and two together**. The kitten on the tree must be that girl's.

"Hey!" Arushi **shouted**. "Are you looking for a kitten? She's right here!"

In a **flash** everybody was there **peering** up at the kitten who peered back at them with bright round eyes. She was still too afraid to climb down.

"Oh, oh, oh!" her little mistress said helplessly, "but how will we get her down?"

It was obvious that none of the children knew how to climb a tree.

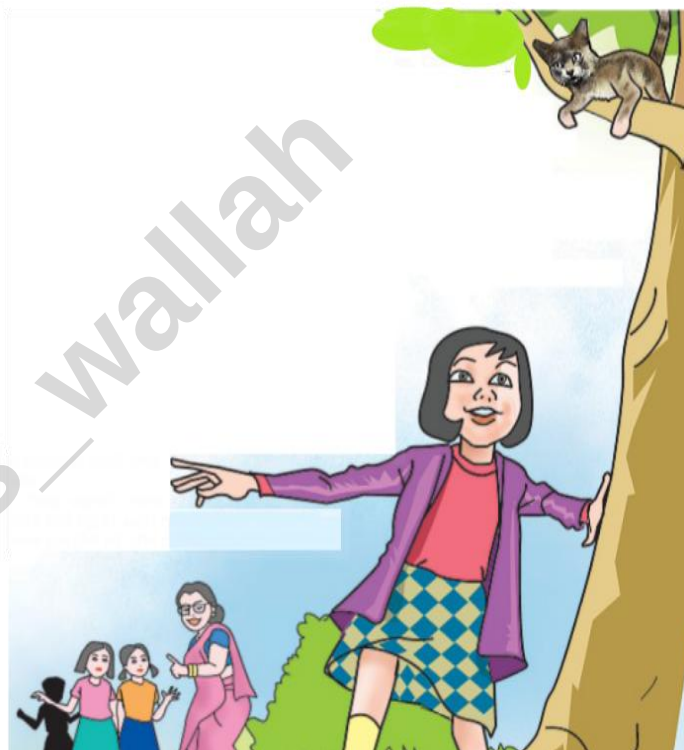
"Don't worry!" Arushi said, throwing off her jacket.

"I'll get her."

In a trice she was up in the tree and close to the kitten, even as the other girls **gaped**.

Cautiously Arushi reached out toward the kitten, who **stiffened** but seemed to sense that the girl didn't mean any harm and let her **cuddle** it under her arm. Arushi climbed down one branch carefully from where she **handed** the kitten to the girl's mother.

It was a hero's welcome that awaited her! The kitten's mistress hugged her tight as her mother **beamed** and the kitten **purred** at her.



"I'm so sorry, we were so **horrid** to you!" she said.

"You were? Avni, that's not right," said her mother. "What a brave girl she is!" she continued. "You deserve a treat. I just finished baking a cake. Come along everybody!"

"Will you teach us how to climb a tree?" a small girl **piped up**.
"I think you are like Superman!"

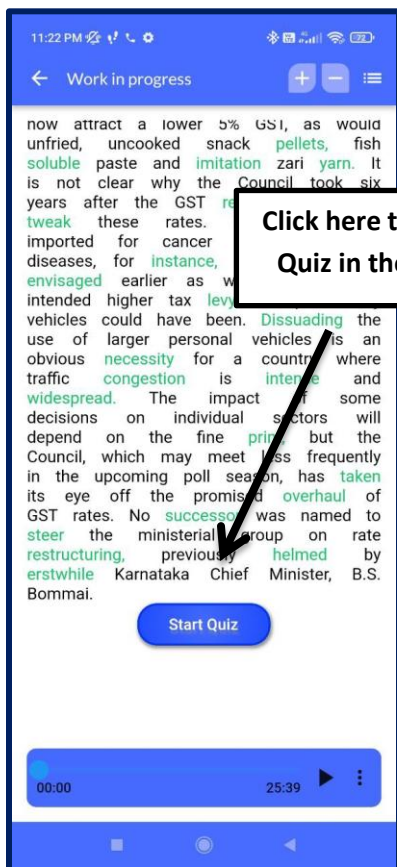
Arushi **blushed**. Wasn't it lovely to have so many friends again — all **thanks to** Kitty, who was purring **contentedly** in her arms!

Vocabulary

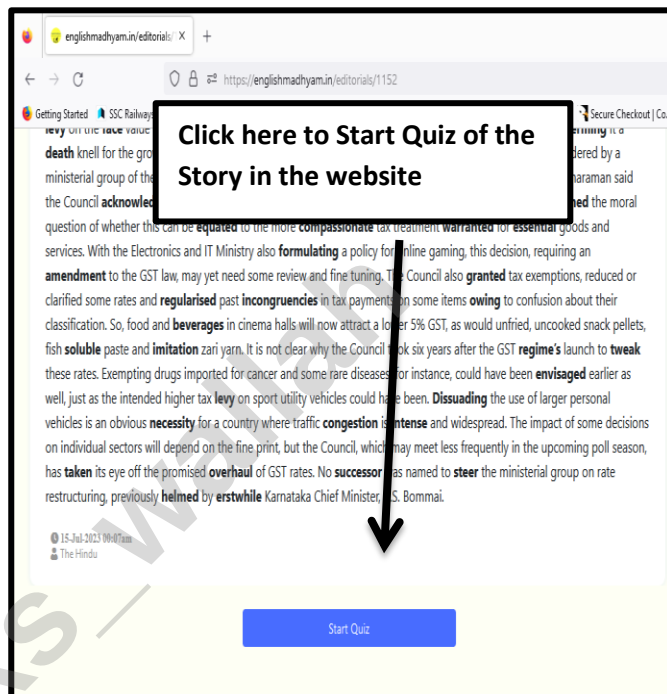
1. **Sorely** (adverb) – greatly, deeply, badly, severely, extremely – अत्यधिक
2. **Dear** (adjective) – beloved, cherished, precious, adored, special – प्रिय
3. **Shy** (adjective) – timid, bashful, reserved, hesitant, introverted – शर्मीला
4. **Venture out** (phrasal verb) – step outside, go forth, move out, go out, set out – बाहर निकलना
5. **Strange** (adjective) – unfamiliar, unknown, odd, unusual, peculiar – अजनबी / अजीब
6. **Walk up** (phrasal verb) – approach, come near, move toward, advance, go up to – पास जाना
7. **Drag on** (phrasal verb) – pull along, tug, trail, haul, move slowly – धीरे-धीरे खींचना
8. **Step out** (phrasal verb) – go out, leave, exit, move out, emerge – बाहर निकलना
9. **Hopscotch** (noun) – skipping game, jumping game – एक बच्चों का खेल (खो-खो जैसा कूदने वाला खेल)
10. **Long** (verb) – yearn, desire, crave, want, wish – तरसना
11. **Smartly turned out** (phrase) – well-dressed, neat, stylish, tidy, well-groomed – अच्छे से तैयार
12. **Scruffy** (adjective) – untidy, shabby, messy, ragged, dirty – गंदा / अस्त-व्यस्त
13. **Hesitantly** (adverb) – reluctantly, shyly, timidly, cautiously, unconfidently – हिचकते हुए
14. **Go on** (phrasal verb) – continue, proceed, carry on, keep doing, persist – चलते रहना
15. **Walk away** (phrasal verb) – leave, depart, go away, turn away, withdraw – दूर चले जाना
16. **Fancy** (verb) – imagine, suppose, think, believe, guess – कल्पना करना
17. **Burst into giggle** (phrase) – start laughing, erupt in laughter, chuckle – हँसी में फूट पड़ना
18. **Snooty** (noun) – snob, stuck-up person, arrogant, haughty, conceited – घमंडी व्यक्ति
19. **About to do something** (phrase) – on the verge of, just going to, ready to, close to – कुछ करने ही वाला
20. **In a huff** (phrase) – angrily, in irritation, in a mood, upset – गुस्से में
21. **Pitiful** (adjective) – pathetic, sad, miserable, sorrowful, distressing – दयनीय
22. **Mew** (noun) – meow, cry, whimper, sound of a cat – बिल्ली की आवाज

23. **Kitten** (noun) – baby cat, young feline – बिल्ली का बच्चा
24. **Perch on** (phrasal verb) – sit on, rest on, be on, roost on – (ऊँचाई पर) बैठना
25. **The little thing** (noun) – Here it refers to little kitten.
26. **Rescue** (verb) – save, help, free, recover, retrieve – बचाना
27. **Wonder** (verb) – think, ponder, question, consider, contemplate – सोचना / आश्चर्य करना
28. **Pleasantly** (adverb) – nicely, agreeably, sweetly, kindly, cheerfully – सुखद रूप से
29. **Plump** (adjective) – chubby, round, pudgy, fat, well-fed – गोल-मटोल
30. **Burst into tears** (phrase) – start crying, break down, cry suddenly – रो पड़ना
31. **Put two and two together** (phrase) – figure out, realize, infer, deduce – अनुमान लगाना
32. **Shout** (verb) – yell, call out, scream, cry out, holler – चिल्लाना
33. **Flash** (adjective) – quick, sudden, instant, momentary, rapid – बहुत तेज़
34. **Peer** (verb) – look closely, gaze, observe, glance, stare – झाँककर देखना
35. **In a trice** (phrase) – instantly, quickly, in a moment, at once – झटपट
36. **Gape** (verb) – stare, gawk, look in surprise, ogle, gaze – मुँह खोलकर देखना
37. **Stiffen** (verb) – tense, freeze, harden, become rigid, tighten – अकड़ जाना
38. **Cuddle** (verb) – hug, embrace, snuggle, hold lovingly, caress – गोद में लेना / प्यार से पकड़ना
39. **Hand** (verb) – give, pass, deliver, offer, present – सौंपना
40. **Beam** (verb) – smile broadly, radiate joy, glow, grin, light up – मुस्कराना
41. **Purr** (verb) – hum, vibrate, murmur (cat sound) – गुर्राना (बिल्ली की आवाज में खुशी से)
42. **Horrid** (adjective) – terrible, nasty, mean, awful, unpleasant – भयंकर / बहुत बुरा
43. **Pipe up** (phrasal verb) – speak up, chime in, interject, say suddenly – अचानक बोल पड़ना
44. **Blush** (verb) – redden, flush, color (from embarrassment), glow – शरमा जाना
45. **Thanks to** (phrase) – due to, because of, owing to, on account of – की वजह से
46. **Contentedly** (adverb) – happily, peacefully, calmly, with satisfaction, cheerfully – संतोषपूर्वक

Practice Exercise



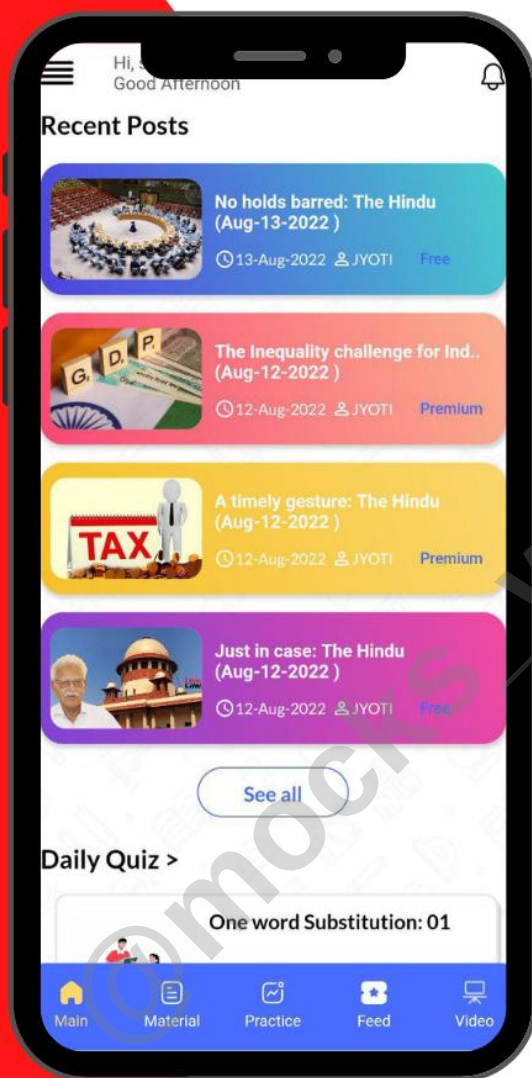
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